

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Data collection methods are the specific techniques used to gather evidence. The main business research instruments are interviews (structured, semi-structured, unstructured), questionnaires and surveys, focus groups, observation (participant or structured), and document/archival analysis. Each has strengths, biases and practical demands; the method is chosen to fit the question, design and philosophy, and its administration should be described precisely enough for another researcher to follow (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2019).

SELF-REPORT METHODS

Interviews: depth, flexibility, rich meaning — but time-intensive and prone to interviewer effects. Questionnaires/surveys: breadth, standardisation, efficiency — but limited depth and dependent on question quality. Focus groups: interaction surfaces shared meaning — but risk of dominant voices.

OBSERVATION & DOCUMENTS

Observation: captures actual behaviour rather than reported behaviour; participant or structured. Documents and archives: existing records, filings, minutes, media — unobtrusive and durable, but produced for other purposes, so read them critically for bias and gaps.

Describe administration, not just choice. State how many interviews, how long, where, recorded how, and with what schedule; how the survey was distributed and over what period; what was piloted and changed. Vague administration is where 'authenticity' doubts begin — precision protects you.

Method	Strength	Watch for
Interview	Depth, flexibility	Interviewer bias, time
Survey	Breadth, standardised	Question wording, response rate
Focus group	Interaction, shared meaning	Dominant participants
Observation	Actual behaviour	Observer effect, ethics
Documents	Unobtrusive, durable	Original purpose, bias

PILOT FIRST

Test interview schedules and questionnaires on a few people. Report what you changed — it demonstrates instrument validity.

KEEP THE RAW DATA

Recordings, transcripts, completed questionnaires, consent forms. 'Findings with no raw evidence' is an authenticity flag.

CONSENT & PROTECTION

Informed consent before collection; anonymise; store securely. This ties directly to the signed Ethics Agreement.

Common pitfalls. (1) No pilot of the instrument. (2) Leading or double-barrelled survey questions. (3) Interview transcripts that are implausibly uniform in length and wording. (4) No raw data or consent forms retained. (5) A method that does not match the stated design.

REFERENCES

Saunders, M., Lewis, P. and Thornhill, A. (2019) *Research Methods for Business Students*. 8th edn. Harlow: Pearson. · Kvale, S. and Brinkmann, S. (2015) *InterViews*. 3rd edn. Thousand Oaks: SAGE. · Bryman, A. and Bell, E. (2015) *Business Research Methods*. 4th edn. Oxford: Oxford University Press.